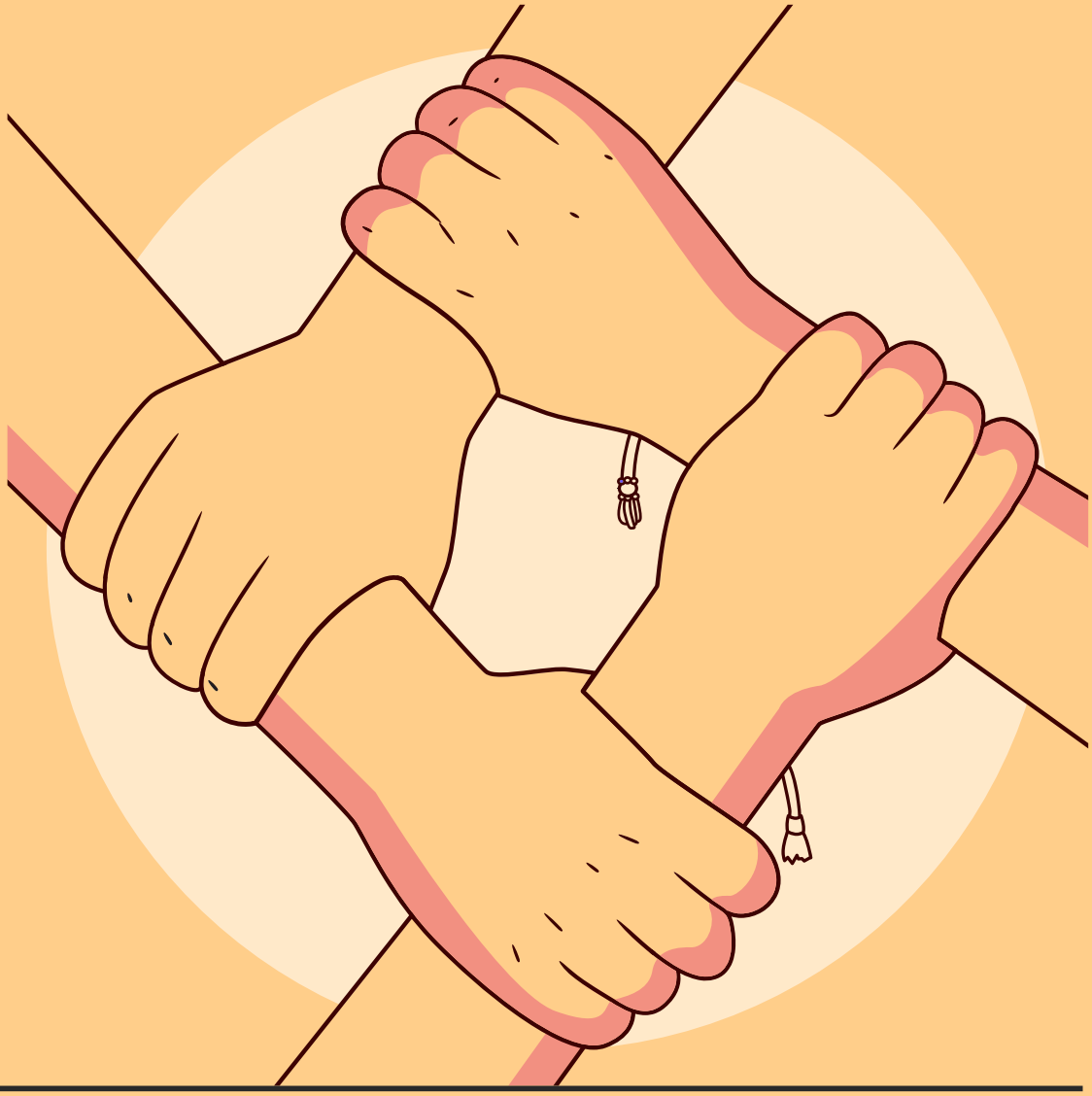
intersex
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CENTER FOR HEALTHCARE DEVELOPMENT & YOUTH EMPOWERMENT



AN INTERSECTIONAL ROUTE TO LEAVING NO ONE BEHIND

A MANUAL FOR

SOCIAL JUSTICE ACTIVISTS AND ADVOCATES

JULY 2024



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We thank **Emitomo Oluwatobiloba "Nimisire"**, our consultant, for her unwavering commitment to creating this manual, excellent work style and delivery, and facilitation of a three-day workshop with the abovementioned activists. This manual is evidence of your diligence and dedication to building a more just and inclusive society for those marginalised and labelled as "difficult to work with" for an extended time. Thank you for your invaluable contribution.

We also want to acknowledge the relentless effort of **Jennifer Aliu-Kadiri**, an intersectional feminist, mental health advocate, and gender and intersex activist, for conceiving this idea to ensure that activists and advocates with the **LBQ movement** and beyond approach their intervention using an intersectional lens, thereby leaving no one behind.

INTRODUCTION

If we are truly committed to leaving no one behind, we must adopt an intersectional approach that helps us identify and acknowledge the diverse ways that people experience social inequality. When we examine social injustice through an intersectional lens, we continually ask questions to recognize how individuals face multiple forms of discrimination and vulnerabilities. This helps us design inclusive solutions that successfully address all aspects of their struggles and intentionally include them in decision-making spaces from which they are typically excluded.

For our advocacy and activism to effectively reach groups most affected by the issues we are addressing, we must understand that people do not lead singular-issue lives. Marginalisation does not affect everyone at the same level; some people are marginalised as a result of multiple factors. For instance, while climate change impacts almost everyone, its effects on women manifest differently. When considering the impact of climate change, we must think of pregnant women, women and girls with mental and physical disabilities, those living in rural communities, as well as those who are both disabled and pregnant.

A person's experience of inequality may be influenced by their sexual orientation, sex characteristics, gender, disability, location, and socio-economic status simultaneously. For example, a person who is bisexual, nonbinary, intersex and lives in Northern Nigeria may experience anxiety disorder and be underemployed due to social discrimination.

We need to discard the patriarchal system of thinking and problem-solving, which limits us to a rigid framework for examining and responding to human rights violations. These experiences are complex and require that we treat them accordingly.

Emerging activists have a crucial role in shaping the future. Collaboration is essential because the future belongs to all of us. Unhealthy competition is detrimental to our collective and individual progress; we must work together and leave no group behind. Achieving this requires deliberate and sustained effort. We are capable of facing challenges head-on and mobilising resources to realise our vision of an inclusive and just society, free from violence, discrimination, and all forms of inequality.

As we struggle for liberation, we must prioritise rest and our well-being to live healthy, fulfilling lives.

WHAT IS THIS MANUAL?

This manual is a comprehensive resource designed to assist social justice advocates and activists in understanding and applying the principles of intersectionality in their work. It provides a detailed framework and group exercises for analysing how various social categories, such as ethnicity, gender, class, age, poverty, location, and disability, intersect to create experiences of oppression or privilege. The manual includes theoretical foundations, practical applications, and case studies to help users and readers integrate intersectional approaches into their advocacy and activism. This resource serves as a guide for planning and executing projects and interventions that are inclusive and equitable.

WHY THIS MANUAL WAS CREATED

This manual addresses the inclusivity gap in Nigerian social justice movements. It explains the importance of prioritising intersectionality for emerging activists, social justice advocates, and feminists. It seeks to galvanise an ideological shift that will translate the global social justice anthem, *"leaving no one behind,"* into real action. It emphasises the need to move beyond merely talking about inclusivity and provides a practical path for accountability to the communities being advocated for. The manual takes into consideration the knowledge gap of young Nigerian social justice advocates and activists, and is designed to provide them with the information and tools necessary to make their activism inclusive and intersectional.

WHO IS THIS MANUAL FOR?

This manual is created for human rights activists and feminists, especially young Nigerian social justice advocates and activists from structurally marginalised groups. **This includes lesbian, bisexual, queer, trans, intersex, people with disabilities (physical, psychological, neurological, etc.), and those living in rural communities.** It is also designed for individuals working with these groups who are seeking knowledge to make their activism more inclusive or tools to support their existing intersectional work.

HOW AND WHEN DO I USE THIS MANUAL?

Are you an LBQ organisation, activists organising an outreach, workshop, campaign, lobbying, project, sensitization, or any other humanitarian or social justice action? This manual provides comprehensive information on ensuring that the groups you are advocating for are not only seen and heard but also actively involved in processes that may influence their lives.

If you have an ongoing project or activity, this manual can be used to evaluate its inclusiveness, appropriateness, and potential effectiveness. Moreover, it can be used as **a tool for reflecting on your personal and organisational principles, politics, and practices as you determine the best course of action.**

AN OVERVIEW OF THE MANUAL

The manual is structured to offer both theoretical insights and practical guidance. It includes the following sections:



Introduction: An overview of the importance of intersectionality in social justice work, particularly in the Nigerian context.

Who is this Manual for?: States the primary audience and suitability of the manual for their work.

How and When to Use this Manual: Practical advice on using the manual for social justice projects and activities.

A Brief History of Intersectionality: A historical perspective of intersectionality, including the key contributions from Black Feminists.

What is Intersectionality?: Definitions and explanations of what constitutes intersectionality, including its theoretical underpinnings and practical implications.

Case Studies: Real-life examples that demonstrate the importance of intersectional analysis in various contexts.

Tenets of Intersectionality: Fundamental principles that underpin intersectional analysis and practice.

Importance of Intersectionality: The significance of adopting an intersectional approach in social justice work.

Human Rights Frameworks on Intersectionality: International conventions, treaties, and agreements that support intersectional approaches.

Application of Intersectionality: A detailed framework for applying intersectionality in various scenarios.

Tools: Additional resources and references for further reading, research, and application. Each section of this manual is designed to provide a thorough understanding of intersectionality, providing users and readers with the knowledge, tools, and interactive activities to make their activism more inclusive, intersectional, and effective. You don't have to read it all at once and can start from any section.

A BRIEF HISTORY OF INTERSECTIONALITY

> *Alienated by both black men's and white women's movements, black women developed their own ways of conceptualizing social identity structures, not as independent axes of demographic classification but as interlocking matrices of privilege and oppression.* - (Collins 1990)

Intersectionality originated from the demand of black women for recognition of the complex ways in which race, gender, and class intersect to influence their social and political experiences. This framework goes beyond the single-issue approach used in feminist theory and anti-racist policies, which tend to focus primarily on the experiences of white women and black men, obscuring distinct forms of layered oppression experienced by black women.



Black feminists argued that their experiences and problems should not be viewed as a combination of those faced by white women and black men. Black women face many problems, and their unique perspectives, identities, and experiences cannot be addressed by examining the experiences of either black men or white women (S. Laurel Weldon).

Before the term "intersectionality" was coined in the 1970s, the concept was used to contextualize the personal experiences of black women facing racial, sexual, heterosexual, and class oppression. Mainstream feminist and black liberation movements did not have the necessary tools to fully address these intersecting oppressions. Intersectionality has been part of the black feminist movement since its inception, which branched off from the aforementioned movements.

Due to the lack of awareness by the two movements, the black liberation movement aimed at ending racism and the mainstream feminist movement aimed at ending sexism, there was a failure to address the complex struggles faced by black women. The use of one-sided accounts of structural disadvantage led to the development of strategies that did not adequately address the various forms of inequality experienced by black women. In response to this, black feminists contended for the adoption of a politics that was anti-racist, unlike the politics of white women, and anti-sexist, unlike the politics of both black and white men – intersectional politics – as chronicled in the Combahee River Collective Statement (1977) by the Combahee River Collective.

Several feminist scholars, including bell hooks, Elisabeth Spelman, Frances E. W. Harper, Sojourner Truth, Ida B. Wells Barnett, Harriet Tubman, Angela Davis, and Audre Lorde, have extensively studied and written about intersectional struggles. They have shared their experiences and those of others through speeches, books, articles, and papers.

The concept of intersectionality was more clearly introduced through naming, definitions, and case studies by Kimberle Crenshaw. Her law articles, "Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex" (1989) and "Mapping the Margins" (1991), analyze and discuss the distinct experiences of black women due to their social identities.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. Who (individual, group, or organization) do you remember when you hear or think of intersectionality in the context of social justice? Why?

2. Which Nigerian social justice activists and feminists promote intersectionality in their work?

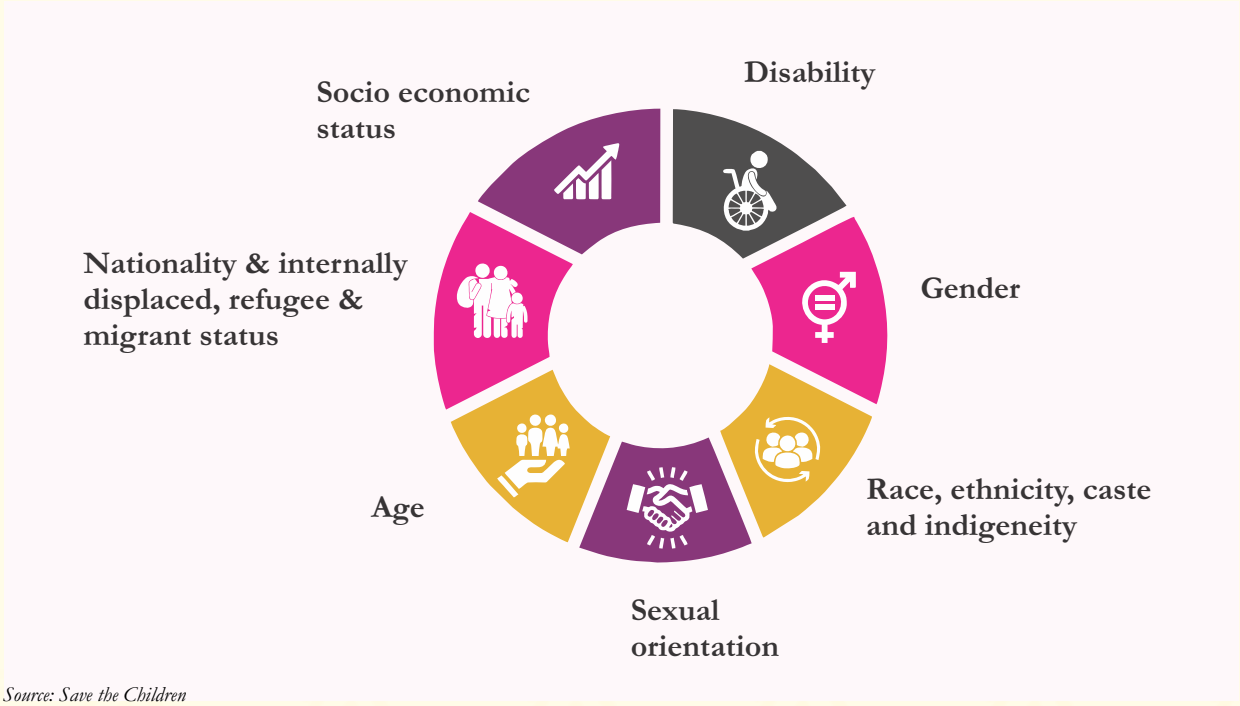
3. What books, materials, or audiovisuals have you read, watched, or listened to that have broadened your understanding and practice of intersectionality? In what way?

4. Which of these resources would you like to revisit or recreate?

WHAT IS INTERSECTIONALITY?

> *There is no such thing as a single- issue struggle because we do not live single-issue lives. Audre Lorde.*

There are many terms used to describe intersectionality, such as *approach, concept, theory, praxis, lens, analytic tool, interpretative methodology, framework, critique, epistemological perspective, research paradigm, field of study, lived experience, and perspective*. Its description as the intersection of social systems of oppression or privilege and its foundation in black feminism are two consistent elements found in all works.



Source: Save the Children

Intersectionality conceptualizes the ways that individuals and groups face multiple forms of discrimination or privilege at once based on the disadvantages (intersectionally marginalized) or advantages (intersectionally privileged) associated with their identities within two or more social categories (such as sex, sexual orientation, ethnicity, caste, descent or inherited status, age, class, disability or health status), rather than a single category. Intersectionality exposes the socio-structural nature of discrimination and inequality and the role of exclusionary social and cultural norms in including or marginalizing certain categories (Sosa, 2017, p. 16).

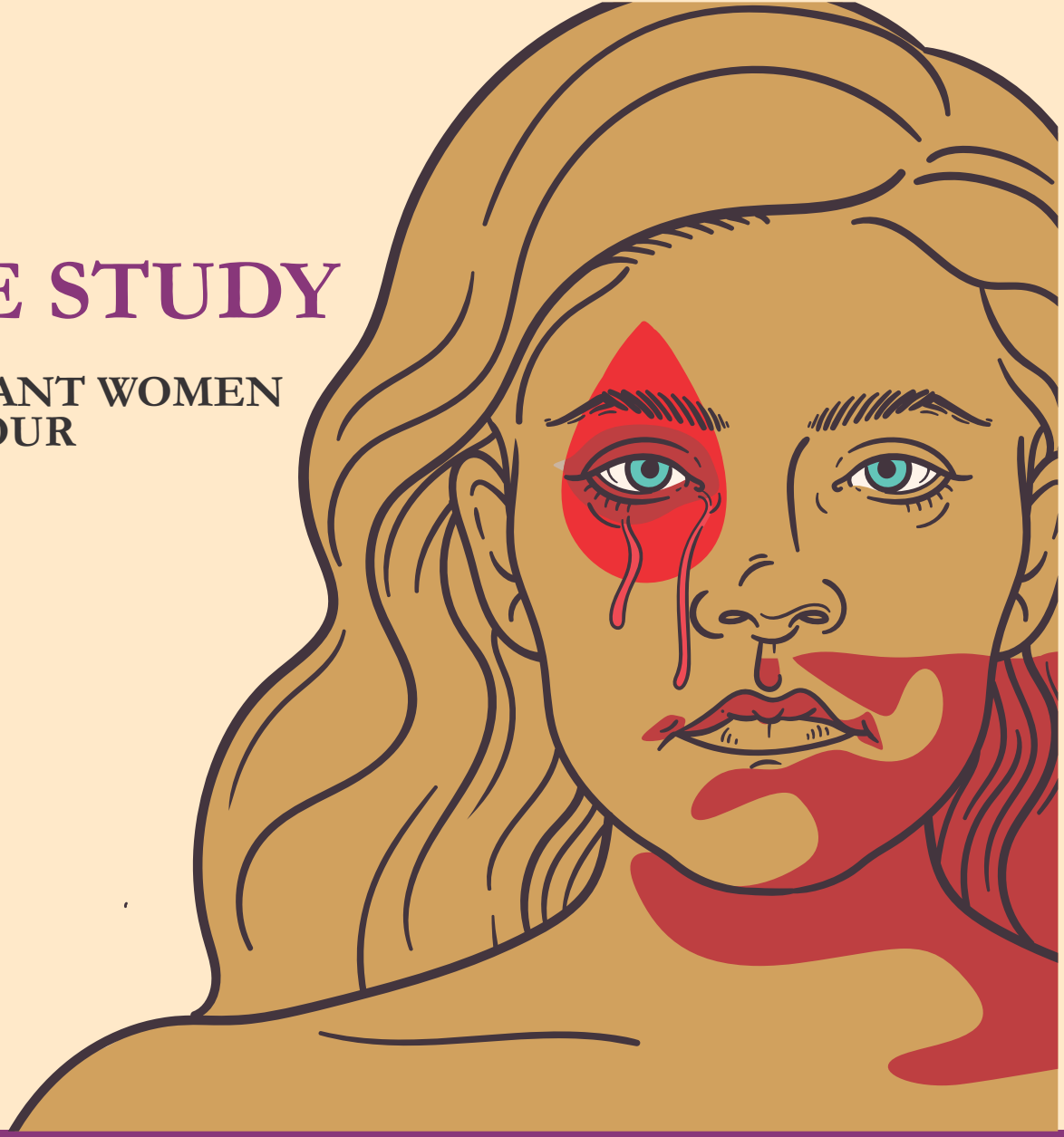
Individuals belong to more than one social category and as a result, they can simultaneously experience both discrimination and privilege. Different combinations of these social categories may increase or decrease the likelihood that a person will experience systemic oppression and discrimination.

As a framework or lens, intersectionality is used to analyse social complexity and address the intersection of social categories at the individual level and the overlapping and interlocking systems of power (laws, policies, state governments, political unions, religious institutions, and media) and oppression that impact different groups in distinct ways at structural levels (Bowleg, 2012).

As a tool, intersectionality is used to engineer appropriate interventions to address marginalisation and social exclusion.

CASE STUDY

IMMIGRANT WOMEN OF COLOUR



In her law articles on intersectionality, Crenshaw explained that the lack of an intersectional approach and use of a single-axis framework in creating legislation on immigration to prevent marriage fraud and provide domestic violence support further marginalized immigrant Women of Colour by forcing them to endure domestic violence due to fear of deportation from the United States. The Marriage Fraud Amendments to the 1986 Immigration Act mandated that newly-wedded couples must be married for two years before the immigrant spouse could apply for permanent resident status.

When Congress created a domestic violence waiver as part of the Marriage Fraud Amendments to address the violence stemming from this state-legislated dependency, domestic violence survivors who were Women of Color remained stuck in abusive homes and couldn't access the waiver or shelters due to structural and language barriers. Many of these women were non-English speakers, unfamiliar with navigating US law enforcement, and lived in communities with residential racial segregation. Although the waiver was open to all women, not all of them were able to access it. The most marginalised group, Women of Color in this case, were the least able to take advantage of it. To address this issue, special programs tailored specifically for women from particular communities were created.

When we use an intersectional lens to examine the personal and social lives of the women studied by Crenshaw in her law articles, it becomes evident that these women faced multiple

layers of oppression due to their social categories. They experienced domestic violence because of their gender as women, were unable to report the violence due to the culture of silence associated with such issues for women from their ethnic groups, and were unable to access shelter and legal support systems because they were non-English speaking immigrants who also faced racial housing discrimination. **Intersectionality establishes that all experiences of marginalisation matter and must be recognized in creating efficient and accessible laws, policies, projects, and services that do not further create erasure and exclusion.**

SITES OF INTERSECTIONAL MARGINALIZATION AND PRIVILEGE

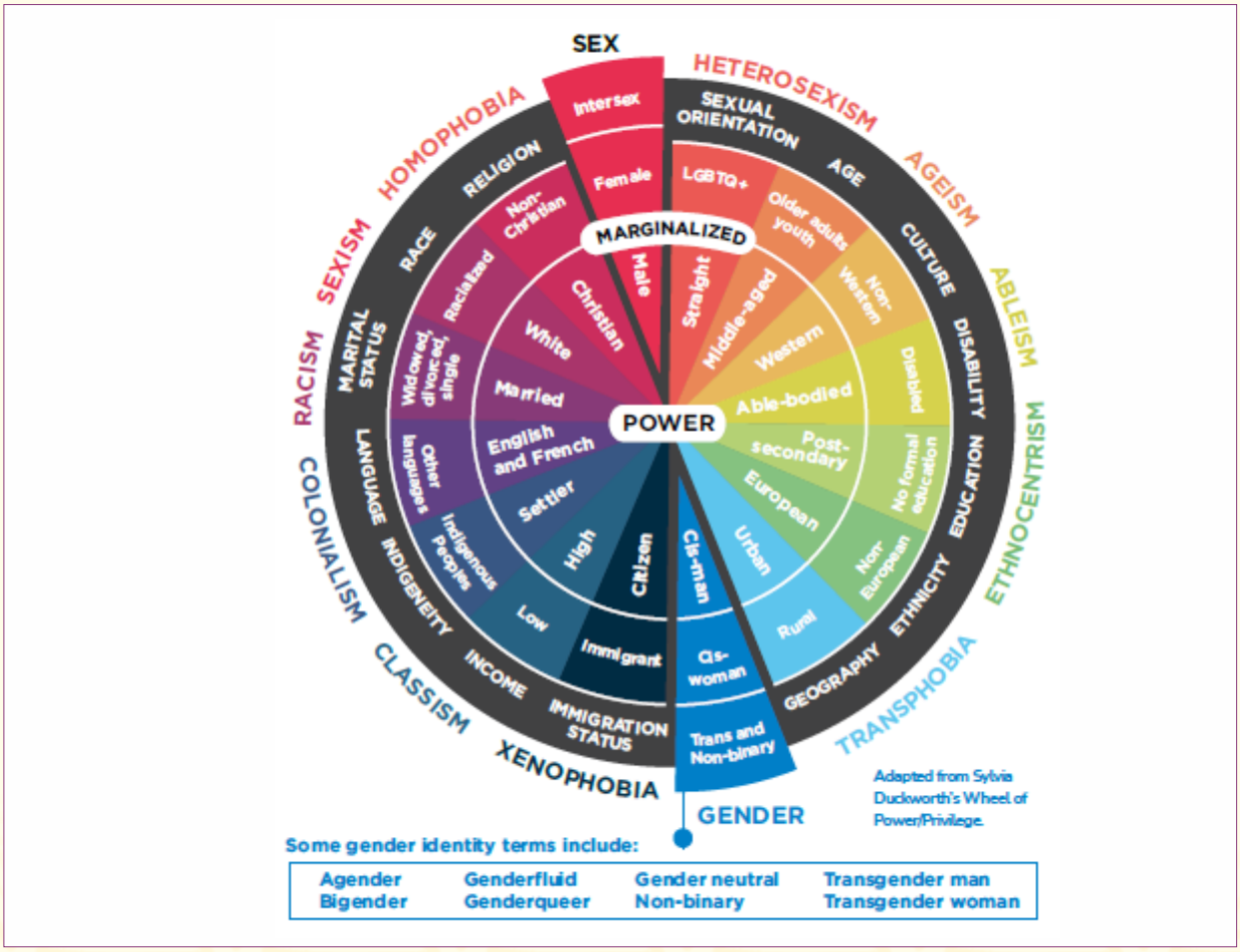


Image credit: Intersectionality Matrix (2022 Handicap International Humanity & Inclusion)

Individuals are either born into or choose their identities within social categories or markers that establish their status and define their degrees of power in relation to others, thereby shaping their life opportunities in society. Each of these social categories has a hierarchy in which dominant groups, possessing more social power, can provide advantages to members who adhere to social norms and restrict opportunities for nondominant members, who have less social power and are often marginalized.

The limitation or denial of access to resources, legal protection, opportunities, discrimination, prejudice, abuse, disadvantages, or disapproval experienced based on social group memberships is known as **oppression**.

Social categories include **gender, age, sexual orientation, disability, race, religion, marital status, health status (e.g., HIV status), ethnicity, caste, indigeneity, socioeconomic status, nationality, migratory, internally displaced,** and **refugee status**. We embody multiple identities simultaneously, which interact and overlap, leading to unique experiences - known as intersectionality.

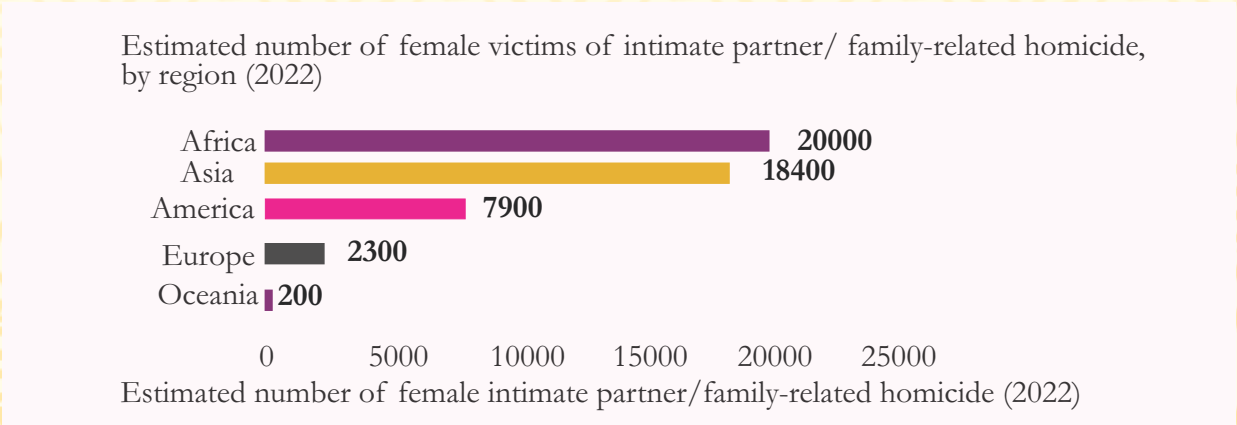
The identities of people under these categories may either be grounds of oppression or privilege, depending on the time and space. People's experience of violence, inequality, discrimination, and exclusion based on their social categories can be interpersonal (between people) or institutional (within systems, organisations, and policies). While privileged groups have power over oppressed groups, a person can experience both oppression and privilege at the same time. For instance, a heterosexual Nigerian woman without a disability might face obstacles when trying to participate in elections because of gender discrimination within political parties, which is a form of oppression. However, she might still have privileges to access certain opportunities or spaces that an intersex Nigerian or a heterosexual woman with mobility impairments may not have due to their sex characteristics and disabilities.

Here are some examples of social categories and their associated historical oppression ingrained in the culture and laws of different societies and upheld by their institutions.

Social Categories	Systems of Oppression
Gender	Sexism, Transphobia
Sexual Orientation	Heteronormativity, Homophobia, Biphobia
Disability	Ableism, Saneism
Socio-economic Status	Classism
Age	Ageism
Race, Ethnicity,Caste, Indigeneity	Racism, Xenophobia, Colourism
Nationality and Migrant, Refugee, & Internally Displaced Status	Racism, Xenophobia, Lack of Legal Status
Body Type	Sizeism,fatphobia
Religion	Islamophobia, Anti-semitism
Health (HIV Status)	Serophobia

GENDER

This encompasses socially constructed roles, behaviours, activities, and attributes that a particular society considers appropriate for girls, boys, women, men and other genders. Gender structures social life, roles, and individual and group values. Gender socialization largely determines how people present themselves and express their gender identity as a man, woman, transgender, intersex, or gender queer. The oppression that people experience as a result of gender stereotypes is known as **sexism**. In most parts of the world women and girls experience gender based violence, discrimination in access to resources, healthcare and education, because cisgender men are considered as superior to cisgender women; a hierarchical view that produces gendered inequalities.



Source: UNODC estimates based on UNODC Homicide Dataset.

Globally, nearly 89,000 women and girls were killed in 2022, with 48,800 of them being killed by their intimate partners or other family members. On average, more than 133 women or girls were killed every day by someone in their own family. Africa had the highest number of these killings in 2022, with 20,000 victims. Most of these intentional killings, also referred to as femicide and feminicide, were committed due to gender-related factors, including male privilege, entitlement, and the enforcement of gender roles through violent punishment.

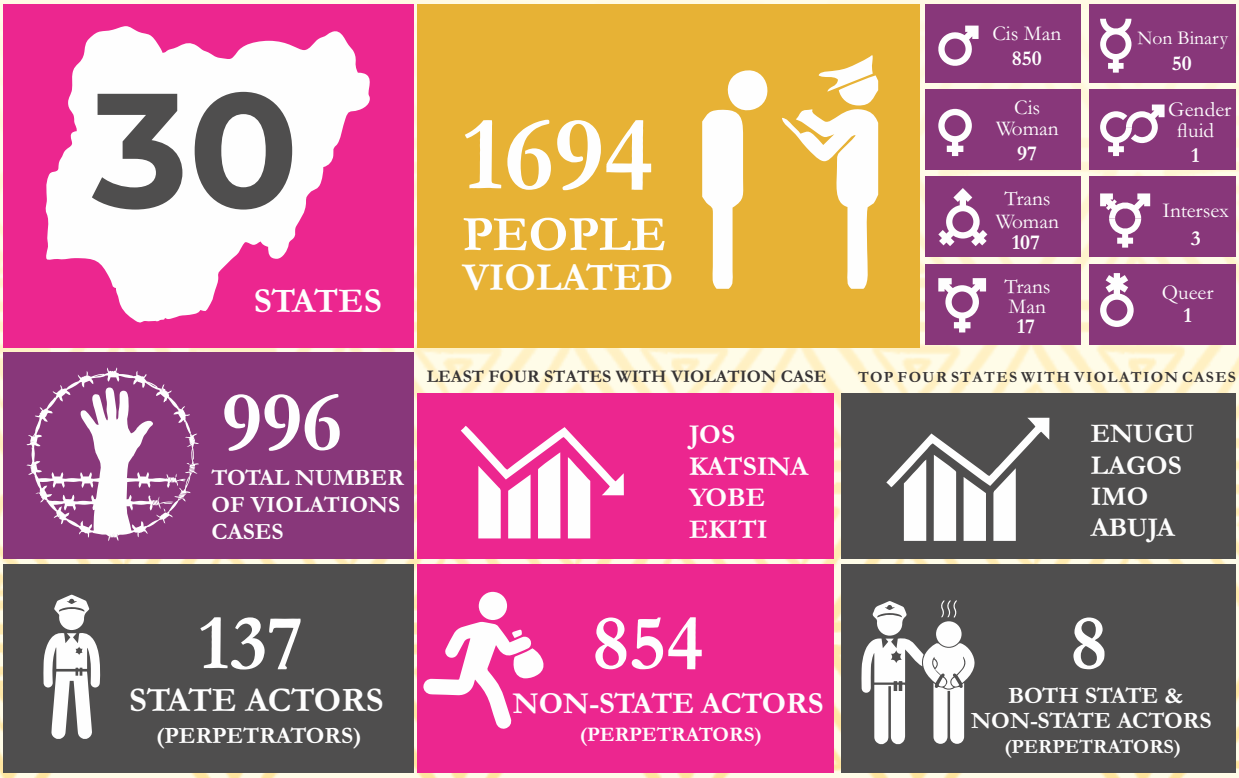
Globally, about 1 in 3 (30%) women worldwide have experienced either physical and/or sexual intimate partner violence or non-partner sexual violence in their lifetime. The prevalence of this type of violence is 33% in Africa. According to the 2018 National Demographic Health Survey (NDHS), 33% of women aged 15-49 in Nigeria have experienced physical or sexual violence.

SEXUAL ORIENTATION

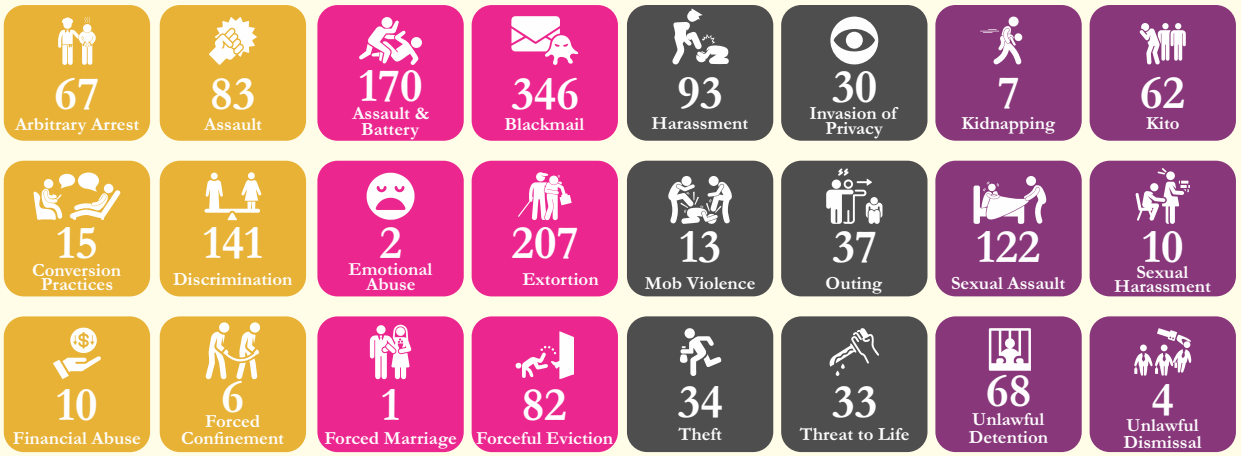
Sexual orientation refers to a person's sexual identity, attraction, interests, desires, and experiences. Human sexuality is diverse, encompassing heterosexuality, homosexuality, bisexuality, pansexuality, asexuality, and more. In many societies, only heterosexuality (sexual attraction between a man and a woman) is widely accepted, and individuals who do not conform to heterosexual norms may face punishment. Currently, 64 countries have laws that criminalize private, consensual, same-sex sexual activity, and 12 of these countries, including Nigeria, impose the death penalty for such acts.

This state-legitimized oppression has furthered exacerbated the violence and exclusion that Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, and Queer people face because of their sexual orientation. This occurs both in their homes and in public, and can involve individuals, state and non-state actors, as well as institutions such as schools, hospitals, and workplaces.

The 2023 Human Rights Violations Report by the Initiative for Equal Rights (TIERs) in Nigeria documented 996 cases of human rights violations based on real or perceived Sexual Orientation, Gender Identity/ Expression And Sex Characteristics (SOGIESC) in Nigeria. The violations included mass arrests, extortion, kidnapping, mob violence, blackmail, assault and battery, theft, rape, invasion of privacy, conversion practices, forceful eviction, and wrongful dismissal. The report emphasizes that the location and socio-economic status of the individuals involved significantly influenced the severity of these violations.



TYPES OF VIOLATIONS



Source: The Initiative for Equal Rights (TIERs), 2023 Human Rights Violations Report

DISABILITY

Disability is any condition that makes it more difficult for a person to engage in certain activities and interact with the world around them. The impairment can be physical, cognitive or developmental, sensory, psychological, or other invisible impairments. Globally, one in six people has a significant disability, with a higher prevalence among women (19 percent) than men (12 percent), and 80 percent of individuals with disabilities live in developing countries in the Global South. In 2018, about 15 percent of Nigeria's national population had a disability, and in 2019, 1 in 10 households had at least one person living with a disability.

Disability is a social problem due to stigma, stereotypes, attitudinal, institutional, environmental, financial, and communication barriers. People with disabilities may face ableism, reducing their quality of life and excluding them from decision-making in their lives and society. They also experience forced institutionalization, infanticide, increased risk of natural and climate hazards, unemployment or underemployment, and difficulties accessing healthcare. The level of discrimination and oppression varies based on their other social categories, and those with other marginalized identities may experience distinct forms of ableism.

Analysis of the 2018 General Household Survey Panel (GHSP) in Nigeria revealed that more women than men experienced functional difficulties due to their disabilities. It was also found that individuals in rural areas faced a higher degree of functional difficulties compared to those in urban areas. As a result, there was a higher multidimensional poverty headcount, lower primary school education, and decreased employment among individuals with functional difficulties compared to those without difficulties.

Prevalence of functional difficulties in Nigeria (%)

GROUP	ANY DIFFICULTY	SOME DIFFICULTY	AT LEAST A LOT OF DIFFICULTY
All adults	6.92	4.59	2.33
Females	7.52	5.12	2.40
Males	6.29	4.03	2.26
Rural residents	7.38	4.75	2.63
Urban residents	5.80	4.19	1.61
Ages 15 to 29	1.85	1.27	0.58
Ages 30 to 44	3.67	2.54	1.13
Ages 45 to 64	9.71	6.83	2.88

Ages 65 and over	38.75	24.04	14.71
Seeing	2.80	2.16	0.64
Hearing	1.14	0.81	0.32
Mobility	3.95	2.76	1.19
Cognitive	2.13	1.66	0.46
Self-care	1.72	1.15	0.57
Communication	0.98	0.70	0.28
All households	18.17	11.67	6.50
Rural households	19.36	11.87	7.49
Urban households	15.58	11.25	4.33

Source: Nigeria 2018 GHSP, own calculations

Key indicators for adults age 15+ by functional difficulty status (% and percentage points)

Indicator	No Difficulty	Some Difficulty	Difference between no difficulty and some difficulty	At least a lot of difficulty	Difference between no difficulty and at least a lot of difficulty
Multi dimensional poverty head count	66	77	11***	87	21***
Less than primary school	34	57	23***	62	28***
Employment population ratio	60	57	2	38	22***
Safety managed drinking water	76	81	-5***	77	-1
Safety managed sanitation	44	36	8***	45	-1
Clean fuel	10	8	2	3	7***
Electricity	47	45	2	46	1
Adequate housing	48	47	1	52	4
Owns assets	27	22	4***	23	3***

*Notes: *, ** and *** indicate that the difference is statistically significant at the 1-%, 5% and 1% levels respectively. Numbers in the difference columns are in percentage points while all other numbers in the table are percentages.*

Women and girls with disabilities are at a higher risk of experiencing gender-based violence and exploitation due to their gender and disability. They are two to four times more likely to experience intimate partner violence compared to women without disabilities. Nigerian women face various barriers when trying to access safe, confidential, and accessible healthcare services, particularly sexual and reproductive healthcare. Consequently, they are frequently at risk of forced marriage, unwanted pregnancies, sterilization, 'virgin testing', 'virgin rape', and female genital mutilation.

EXERCISE I



OBJECTIVE:

To identify and discuss different combinations of social categories that result in distinct intersectional experiences, using personal or observed experiences.



INSTRUCTIONS

1. Discuss examples of intersectional experiences of prejudice, oppression, discrimination, exclusion, and privilege based on the combination of the following categories:
   a. class and gender
   b. religion and sexual orientation
   c. ability and class
   d. gender, sexual orientation, and class.

2. What different outcomes or experiences would these case studies have if they had more social power as a result of their identities?

3. How can you, as an activist, increase their social power at individual, micro or macro levels of social structure?

EXERCISE II



OBJECTIVE

This identity mapping table and reflection questions were adopted from "A Map of Myself" by Harlap (2008), Diane J. Goodman and UBC Peer Program Training Modules: Diversity & Intercultural Communication to help you understand how your social categories shape your life experience by guiding you in articulating and reflecting on implicit and explicit domains of your identity.



INSTRUCTIONS

1. Write your identity in Column B corresponding to each identity domain in Column A.

2. In the top row on Column C, write the places where you live now (and lived as a child, if it is different from where you live now).

3. For each identity domain on Column B, consider if it puts you in a position of privilege or marginalization. Write "P" for privilege and "M" for marginalization on Column C.

4. Proceed to Reflection Questions.

IDENTITY MAPPING TABLE

A. Domains	B. My Identity/Identities	C. Does this identity give me a position of privilege (P) or marginalization (M) relative to most people in:	
		The place I live now [ ]	The place I lived as a child [ ]
Race (e.g. black, biracial)			
Nationality (e.g. Nigerian)			
Ethnicity (e.g., Ijaw, Ibibio, Tiv)			
Biological sex (e.g., male, female, intersex)			
Gender identity (e.g., woman, man, transgender)			
Sexual orientation (e.g., lesbian, gay, heterosexual, bisexual)			
Religion			
Socio-economic class (e.g., owning middle, working class)			
Dis/ability (e.g., able-bodied, disabled)			
First language			
Other [ ]			

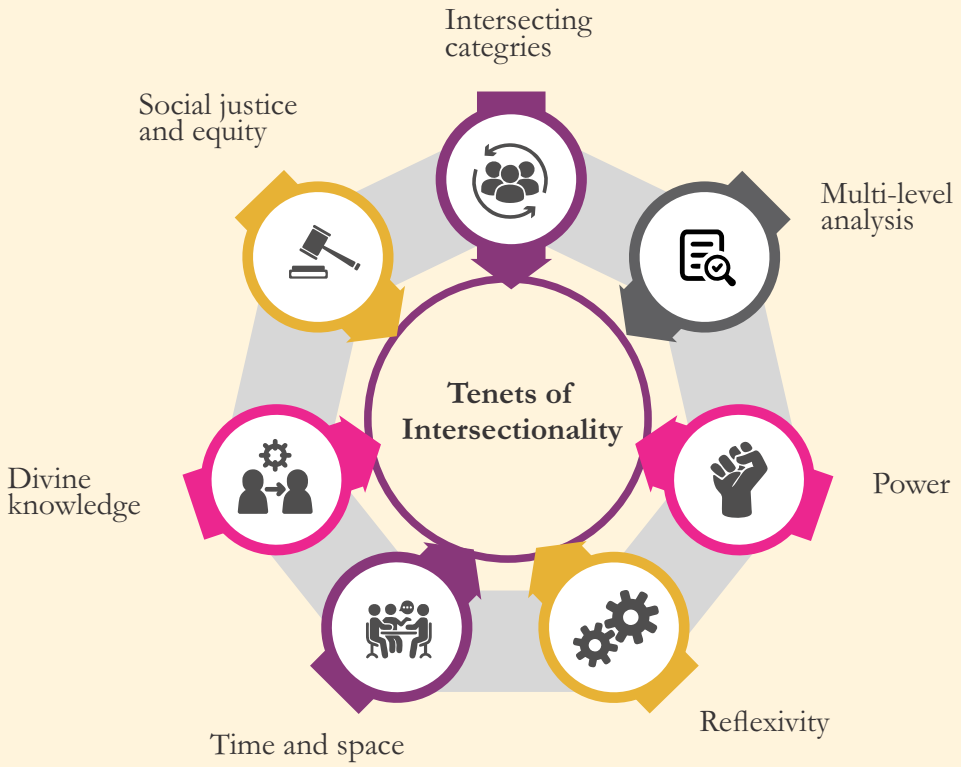
REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. Considering all your social identities listed in the table above, on a daily basis, which ones are you most aware or conscious of? You can pick more than one domain if you want.
   a) Most aware/conscious of:
   b) What do you appreciate about or gain from that identity?
   c) What is the most negative or difficult thing about that identity?

2. Considering all your social identities listed in the table above, on a daily basis, which ones are you least aware or conscious of? You can pick more than one domain if you want.
   a) Least aware/conscious of:
   b) What do you appreciate about or gain from that identity?
   c) What is the most negative or difficult thing about that identity?

3. What stood out most to you in this exercise? Why?

TENETS OF INTERSECTIONALITY



INTERSECTING CATEGORIES

Human lives are complex and fit into more than a single category. These categories interact and intersect to create unique experiences which are studied in intersectional analysis. These intersecting positions have varying degree of power and privilege, some more than others, depending on the place and time. These categories and their importance cannot be predetermined, they must be discovered through an intersectional analysis and not essentialized (none of these categories is more important than the other and it must not be assumed that people who belong to a particular social category have the same experiences and needs, for example the perspectives and needs of intersex person may vary according to their age, income, sexuality, and geographical location).

MULTILEVEL ANALYSIS

Social categories are dynamic, historically grounded, socially constructed, and work at both micro and macro structural levels (Burgess-Proctor, 2006; Weber & Parra-Medina, 2003). The systems at these levels influence the identity, sense of self, choices, and shape how resources, opportunities, and services are distributed, accessed, controlled, and used. Intersectionality recognizes that people do not exist in a vacuum and therefore its enquiry investigates the relationship and interactions between different levels of society, at macro (national and global institutions and policies), meso (regional institutions and policies), and micro levels (grassroots and community-level institutions, policies, and individuals). Intersectionality addresses processes of inequity and differentiation across these levels of structure, based on identity and representation. Multilevel analysis that link individual experiences to meso and macro structures reveal how power relations are shaped.

POWER

Social categories are shaped by power; violence, discrimination, inequality, and exclusion are all expressions of power that can be based on real or perceived identities. Power relations include power over, under, and with others. Power can be visible (control over people's choices and access to resources) or invisible (for setting agenda and influencing decision-making in public and political discourse). Intersectionality draws attention to how power hierarchies and interconnected systems of oppression that cause inequality mutually construct one another (Collins 1998: 63) and the processes by which power and inequity are produced, reproduced and actively resisted (Dhamoon, 2011).

REFLEXIVITY

This is a practice of paying critical attention to and reflecting on the importance and exercise of power at the individual and macro levels of society and in interpersonal relationships. As activists from marginalized groups, it is easy to assume that you have enough lived experience to make informed equitable and just decisions, reflexivity helps us decentre ourselves to acknowledge different perspectives and experiences that are usually excluded from decision-making. Reflexivity is instrumental in approximating our social position and tracing our personal historical connections to oppressive systems so that we can disrupt unjust cycles.

TIME AND SPACE

How we understand and navigate the world, and make meaning of our social categories and associated orders is shaped by the time and space we exist in (Saraga, 1998). Power dynamics are not static, relationships between social categories change over time and vary according to geographical context. Time and space are not fixed, but are fluid and changeable (Tuan, 1977). For example, a Nigerian intersex person may not experience oppression on the basis of their national identity while in Nigeria, but face racism in another country.

DIVERSITY OF KNOWLEDGES

Hegemonic power structures typically favour and place Western and Eurocentric knowledge and expertise over indigenous knowledge. Intersectionality draws attention to the traditional knowledge, theories, perspectives, skills and tools of marginalized people in knowledge production, policymaking, project design, evidence and data gathering in research, to disrupt power inequalities and destabilize dominant fundamentalist ideologies that are activated or sustained through these processes.

SOCIAL JUSTICE AND EQUITY

Intersectional processes are typically designed to challenge inequality and lead to interventions that are socially just and the equitable redistribution of power, resources, and opportunities, and transformation of power relations, for people to live dignified lives.



HUMAN RIGHTS FRAMEWORKS ON INTERSECTIONALITY

> Every one of us is born free and equal in dignity and rights.
> The Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

While there are no specific provisions in most human rights instruments which the Nigerian government has passed, signed, or is a party to, that explicitly acknowledge and address the intersectional discrimination that people experience, many of them recognize that race, colour, gender, sex, language, religion, political or other opinion, national or social origin, descent, property, birth and other social categories are grounds of discrimination and root cause of inequality, and set non-discrimination and equality as essential standards for all individuals and groups to fully exercise and enjoy their civil, political, economic, social and cultural rights.

INTERNATIONAL POLICIES

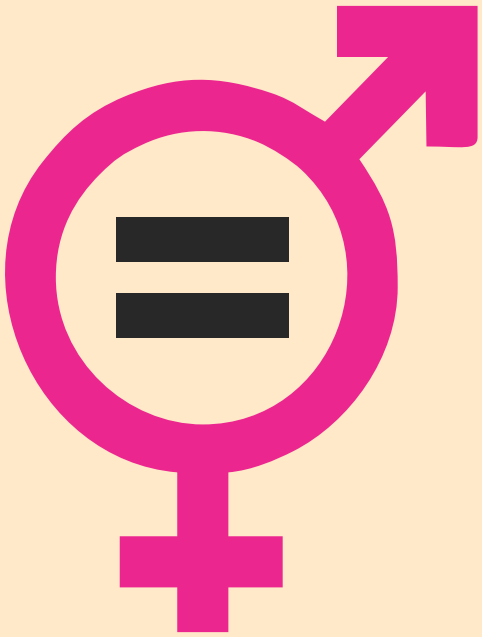
- The Universal Declaration of Human Rights
- The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights
- The International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights
- The International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination
- The International Labour Organization (ILO) Discrimination (Employment and Occupations) Convention, 1958 (No. 111) and its accompanying Recommendation No. 111
- The 1965 International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination
- The 1979 Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW)
- The 1989 Convention on the Rights of the Child
- The 1989 Indigenous and Tribal Peoples Convention (ILO Convention No. 169)
- The 1990 International Convention on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of Their Families
- The 1992 Declaration on the Rights of Persons Belonging to National or Ethnic, Religious and Linguistic Minorities
- The 2006 Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities
- The 2010 HIV and AIDS Recommendation (ILO Recommendation No. 200)
- The 1951 Convention relating to the Status of Refugees
- The 1961 Convention on the Reduction of Statelessness

REGIONAL POLICIES

- The African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights (Charter), also called the Banjul Charter
- African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights on the Rights of Women in Africa ("The Maputo Protocol") (2003)

NATIONAL POLICIES

- The Constitution Of The Federal Republic Of Nigeria 1999 (As Amended)
- Nigeria National Policy On HIV & AIDS 2020
- The Child Rights Act, 2003
- The Violence Against Persons (Prohibition) Act, 2015
- The Discrimination Against Persons With Disabilities (Prohibition) Act, 2018
- The National Senior Citizens Act, 2017
- The Administration Of Criminal Justice Act, 2015
- The Universal Basic Education Law 2004
- The National Health Act 2014
- The National Health Policy 2016
- The National Employment Policy 2017
- Nigeria's National Social Protection Framework
- The National Gender Policy 2006 (Reviewed In 2014)
- Second National Action Plan On The Implementation Of UN Security Council Resolution 1325 And Related Resolutions On Women, Peace And Security (2017)
- The National Policy On Special Needs
- The Federal Character Principle



IMPORTANCE OF INTERSECTIONALITY

GENDER TRANSFORMATION

An intersectional approach addresses the structural causes of inequality and intersecting discrimination by transforming imbalanced hierarchal power relationships between individuals, groups and communities through policies, institutions, and by shifting harmful socio-cultural norms and gender stereotypes to promote equitable alternatives.

Inclusion: Intersectional analysis acknowledges that no discrimination is more important than the other and exposes all the ways that people are excluded from accessing resources and exercising their human rights as everyone else and encourages the development and implementation of inclusive strategies that increase . Intersectionality is a critical tool for ensuring that no one is “left behind" as pledged by UN Member States when the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and its Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) was adopted.

STRATEGIC COLLABORATION FOR LIBERATION

Intersectionality provides an opportunity for people of diverse social categories, backgrounds, and locations to organize collectively based on an identified common struggle, leading to the formation of coalitions and alliances that promote social justice, non-discrimination and equality.

DISAGGREGATED DATA

Intersectionality necessitates the collection, analysis and use of data from multiple axes (e.g., racial/ ethnicity, sexuality, socioeconomic status, gender, ability, and immigration status, etc.) to identify who is left behind in an advocacy or intervention and the meaningful engagement groups most affected as experts on an issue, to ensure that appropriate accommodations are made and prevent or mitigate the perpetuation of harm and intersectional discrimination.

EXERCISE III: ICE-BREAKER - AN INTERSECTIONALITY YARN GAME

This game is adapted from community education activities for exploring intersectionality in an Intersectionality Toolkit by The International Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender and Queer Youth and Student Organisation (IGLYO).



MATERIALS NEEDED:

A ball of string/yarn enough for the number of participants (minimum of five and maximum of 12 people).



LENGTH OF THE ACTIVITY:

10 to 20 minutes, depending on the number of participants.

GUIDANCE NOTE FOR FACILITATOR

1. Have participants gather in a circle.

2. Show participants the ball of yarn/string and explain to them that everyone will be sharing something about themselves to see how each person is connected. You will be exploring people's similarities and differences.

3. To get started, tell people that you will begin saying things about yourself. Explain to people that once you start talking, if someone hears you say something that she/he has in common with you, then that person should interrupt your dialogue and take over where you left off. For example, if you both have kids or if you share a hobby in common.

4. Begin talking about yourself.

5. Once someone starts to elaborate on what they have in common with you, hold on to a piece of the string with one hand and toss the rest of the ball to that person.

6. Each time a new person has something in common with the current person speaking, the ball of yarn should be tossed to that person. No one should be letting go of her/his little piece of the string.

7. Once every single person is holding a piece of string, you can stop the game. You may want to instruct people not to talk, once they have had their turn. That way everyone will get a piece of string faster.

8. While people are still holding on to the string, you can point out how complex and interwoven people's experiences are. Point out the complex weave of string and how it intersects at different points. You can draw attention to the various intersections of the string. This can then lead the group into a discussion about what intersectionality is.

INTERSECTIONALITY IN PRACTICE

An Intersectional Analysis and Action Framework

The questions and the table below will guide you in conducting an intersectional analysis to enable you prioritize the inclusion and accessibility needs of marginalized groups that could benefit from your project. The questions may be adapted for a baseline analysis or administered as survey.

1. What are the **social identities** of the groups your project is designed for? For example, do they come from structurally marginalized or prejudiced communities? Do they have different gender, socio-economic backgrounds, or sexual orientation, abilities, first language?

2. Is your project focused on **Agency** (Commitment, Knowledge and Skills), **Access To and Control Over Resources and Opportunities**, **Social Norms** (Attitudes, Exclusionary Practices) or **Laws** (Policies, Programmes, Resource Allocation, Accountability Mechanisms)?

3. Which of the groups' **social categories** are affected by the focus of your project? List the privileged and prejudiced identities in this context.

4. Which **combination** of these **identities** result in **distinct experiences** (intersectional barriers, discrimination, or inequality) of **oppression** or privilege?

5. How do these distinct experiences prevent the affected groups from benefiting from your project?

6. How can you **transform** these **distinct experiences** to ensure all rightsholders benefit from your project (*e.g. Changing how resources are produced or distributed, removing physical, transportation, information and communication barriers or provision of reasonable alternatives, addressing attitudinal, environmental, or institutional barriers, reinforcing autonomy and improving self efficacy*).
7. How will **addressing** identified **intersectional barriers** impact or define (a) Project plan (b) Delivery project activities (c) Indicators of success for project (d) Project Budget (e) Project communication (f) Human resource for project delivery (e) Partnerships (d) Organizational structure?

8. How will **ignoring** identified **intersectional barriers** impact or define (a) Project plan (b) Delivery project activities (c) Indicators of success for project (d) Project Budget (e) Project communication (f) Human resource for project delivery (e) Partnerships (d) Organizational structure?

9. Which of the options (questions 7 and 8) is more applicable to achieve the desired outcomes?

10. What are the barriers to choosing (7)? How can you remove them?

Social Identities of Rightsholders	Combination of SocialIdentities resulting in distinct intersectional experiencesin (as applicable to projectfocus area):	Number of rightsholders with similar intersecting experiences	How can you address these barriers?	What do you need to address these intersectional barriers?	How will addressing these barriers impact the deliveryof yourproject activities?	How will ignoring these barriers impact the delivery of your project activities?

INTERSECTIONALITY TOOLS

Click the link in the texts below or copy them and paste in an online search tool to access these materials.

Disability and Gender Analysis Toolkit (cbm.org)

Intersectionality Toolkit - IGLYO

Gender Equality and Intersectional Analysis Toolkit - CRIAW-ICREF–Intersectionality Resource Guide And Toolkit UN Women and UNPRPD

Intersectionality in Gender-Based Violence Programming - USAID

Save the Children's Gender and Power (GAP) Analysis Guidance

–Privilege Walk Exercise Make Way

Addressing exclusion through intersectionality in rule of law, peace, and security context - UN Women

The United Nations Sustainable Development Group (UNSDG) guide, Operationalizing Leaving No One Behind: Good Practice Note for UN Country Teams

Intersex SRHR Toolkit - A comprehensive guide for human rights defenders and organizations in Nigeria

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